Moving around

New positions, sharps and flats, thumb-under, and your first scales.

How to use these notes

Read alongside the lessons or keep beside your piano. Review the explanations, try the practice tasks, then use the checklist without on-screen hints. Listening and demonstrations are available in the app. Notation examples show the opening two bars; full songs are in the Songbook.

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1. Landmark notes and ledger lines

Signposts on the staff, and notes above and below it.

Landmark notes

Instead of counting up from the bottom line every time, good readers learn a few **landmark notes** and read from the nearest one.

Treble **G** sits on the line the treble clef curls around. Bass **F** sits on the line between the bass clef's two dots. **Middle C** sits on a short line between the staves. Two more Cs make easy signposts: treble C in the **third space**, and bass C in the **second space**.

Practise · Landmark hops

Hop between the landmarks: Middle C, treble G, treble C. Use whatever fingers feel comfortable.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Bass landmarks

Now your left hand: bass C, bass F, and up to Middle C.

Ledger lines

Music can go higher or lower than the five lines. Short extra lines called **ledger lines** extend the staff. Middle C is the one you already know.

Keep the pattern going: above the top line of the treble staff (F) comes G in the space just above, then **A on the first ledger line**, and C on the second. Below the bass staff it's the mirror: F hangs just under the bottom line, and **E sits on the first ledger line**.

> **Review**
>
> What is this note?
>
> **Answer:** A One ledger line above the treble staff is A: top line F, space G, ledger line A.

> **Review**
>
> What is this note?
>
> **Answer:** C The third space of the treble staff is treble C, one of the landmarks. (It's the C in F-A-C-E.)

> **Review**
>
> What is this note?
>
> **Answer:** F The line between the bass clef's dots is F. That's why it's also called the F clef.

> **Review**
>
> What is this note?
>
> **Answer:** E One ledger line below the bass staff is E: bottom line G, space F, ledger line E.

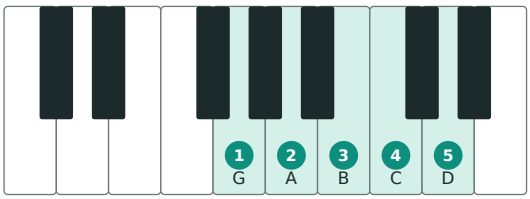
2. G position

Moving your hands to a new home.

A new home

Your hands don't have to stay on C. Move the right hand up so the thumb sits on the **G** just above Middle C. Now your fingers cover **G A B C D**.

The pattern of fingers is exactly the same as before. Only the starting note changed.

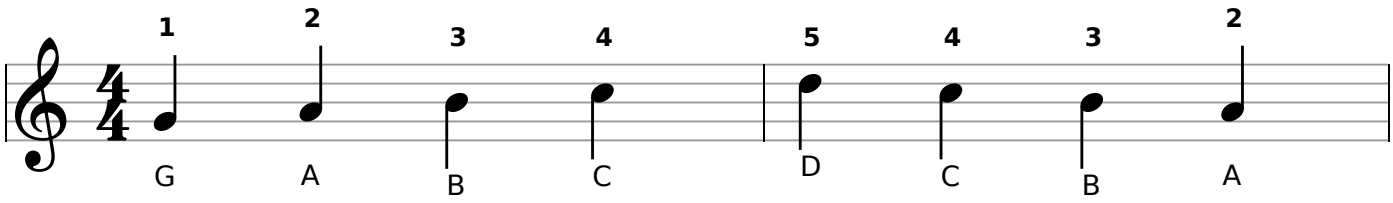


Right hand G position: thumb on G

Figure 4.1 · A new home

Practise · Right hand G position

Thumb on G. Play up and down: G A B C D C B A G.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Left hand G position

Left pinky on the G below Middle C. Play up and down.

Practise · Ode to Joy in G

The same tune, moved to G position. Same fingers as before!

3. Sharps and flats

Naming the black keys.

Up a little, down a little

The black keys are named after their white neighbours. A **sharp** ♯ means "one key higher" and a **flat** ♭ means "one key lower".

So the black key just right of F is **F**♯ (F sharp). The black key just left of B is **B**♭ (B flat). Every black key has two names: F♯ is the same key as G♭.

The distance from any key to its very nearest neighbour is called a **half step**.

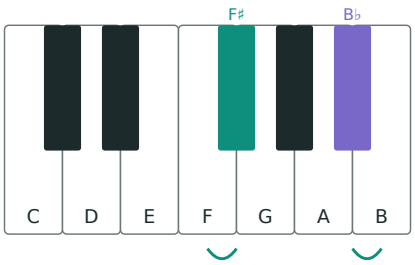
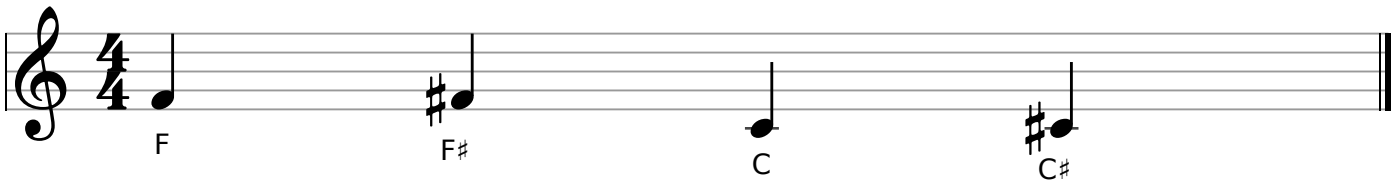


Figure 4.2 · Up a little, down a little

Practise · Find the sharps

Play F, then F sharp. Then C, then C sharp.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Find the flats

Play B, then B flat. Then E, then E flat.

> **Review**
>
> F♯ is the black key…
>
> **Answer:** Just right of F Sharp means one key higher, so F♯ is just to the right of F.

> **Review**
>
> What is another name for the black key between C and D?
>
> **Answer:** D♭ It's both C♯ (C raised) and D♭ (D lowered).

Natural signs and key signatures

A **natural** ♮ cancels a sharp or flat: play the white key.

Sometimes the sharps or flats are written once at the start of every line. That's a **key signature**. A sharp on the F line means **every F is F♯** unless you see a natural. You'll meet this in the next lessons.

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4. Doxology in G major

The key it's sung in, with its one sharp.

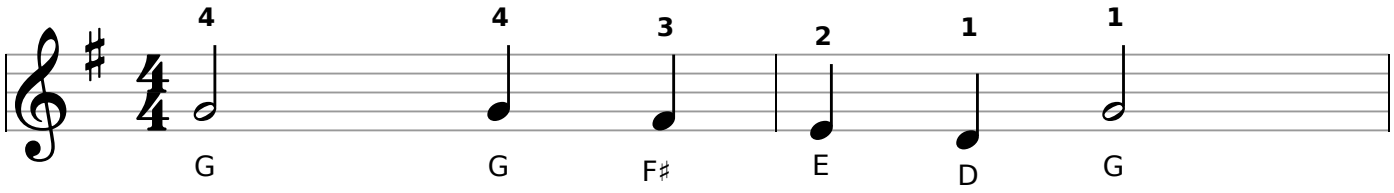
The hymnal key

Hymnals print the Doxology in **G major**, so a congregation can sing it comfortably. G major has one sharp, **F♯**, shown at the start of every line.

The melody is exactly the same shape as before, just starting on G instead of C. Only one note is sharp: the F♯ in lines one and three.

Practise · Lines 1 and 2

Finger 4 on G above Middle C. Walk down G, F♯, E, D, then thumb back to G and up.



Opening example · 4/4 · G · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Lines 3 and 4

Line three dips to E and climbs F♯, G. Line four starts on the high D.

Practise · The whole Doxology in G

From the top, in the hymnal key.

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5. O Christmas Tree

The German carol in G major, with an F sharp.

O Tannenbaum

O Tannenbaum is the German carol known in English as "O Christmas Tree". It's in **G major**, so watch for the one **F♯** near the end of the first line.

It's in 3/4 with a one-beat pickup on D. The middle part climbs higher, up to E.

Practise · O Christmas Tree

Count "3" for the pickup D, then "1 2 3".



Opening example · 3/4 · G · finger 1 = thumb

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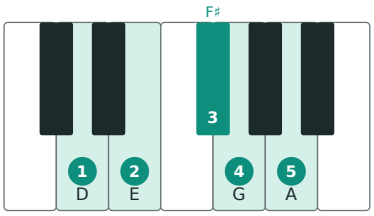
6. D position and F sharp

A five-finger position with a black key.

Major five-finger pattern

Listen to C D E F G: it sounds bright and happy. That sound is called **major**. To get the same sound starting on D, you need one black key: **D E F♯ G A**.

Your third finger reaches forward onto F♯. Keep the hand relaxed and let the finger move in, rather than twisting the wrist.

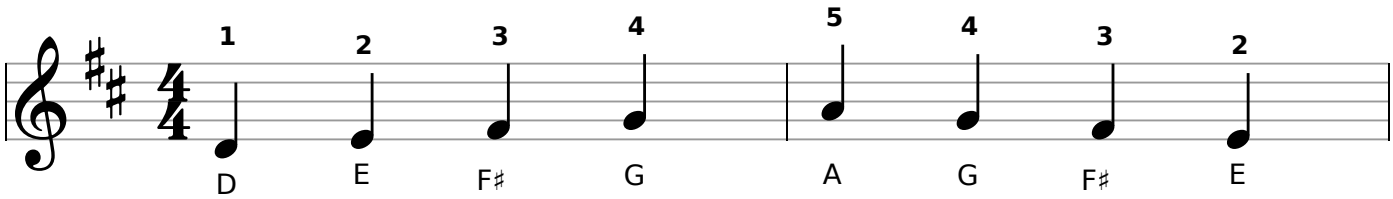


D position: finger 3 on the black key F♯

Figure 4.3 · Major five-finger pattern

Practise · D position

Thumb on D. Play up and down, with finger 3 on F sharp.



Opening example · 4/4 · D · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Mary in D

The key signature has two sharps, but in this tune only F♯ appears.

7. Shall We Gather at the River

Robert Lowry's hymn in D major.

A hymn in D

Robert Lowry wrote **Shall We Gather at the River**, words and tune, in 1864. It sits in your new **D position**, with F♯ under finger 3, and reaches up to the high D in the refrain.

The refrain has a **C♯** just below the high D.

Practise · Verse

Thumb on D. The verse stays close to home.



Opening example · 4/4 · D · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Shall We Gather at the River

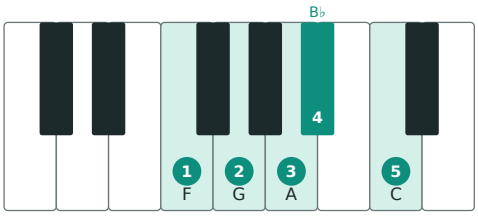
Verse and refrain.

8. F position and B flat

A five-finger position with a flat.

F major position

Starting on F, the major pattern needs a **B♭**: **F G A B♭ C**. The key signature of F major has one flat on the B line.

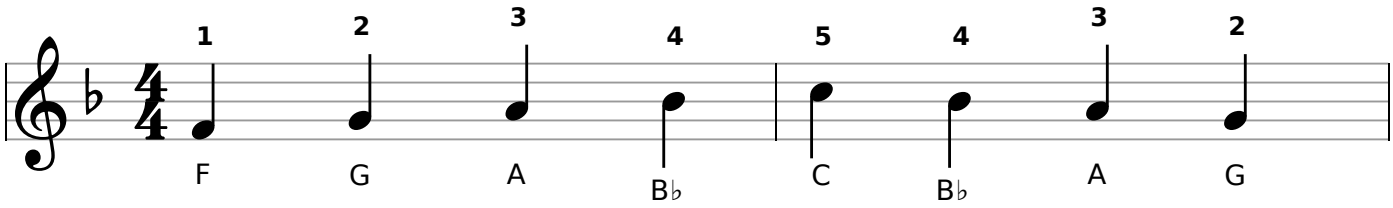


F position: finger 4 on B♭

Figure 4.4 · F major position

Practise · F position

Thumb on F. Finger 4 plays B flat.



Opening example · 4/4 · F · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Hot Cross Buns in F

Hand in F position: A G F with fingers 3 2 1.

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9. What a Friend We Have in Jesus

A much-loved hymn in F major, with B flat.

A hymn in F

Joseph Scriven wrote these words in 1855 for his mother, and Charles Converse's tune came in 1868. It's in **F major**, so every B is **B♭**.

Each line starts with a **dotted quarter** and then runs in eighth notes. Line five has one F♯, just before the climb up to the high D.

Practise · Lines 1 and 2

"What a friend we have in Jesus, all our sins and griefs to bear."



Opening example · 4/4 · F · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · What a Friend We Have in Jesus

All eight lines. Lines 1, 3 and 7 are the same tune.

10. Thumb under

The trick for playing more than five notes.

Crossing the thumb

Five fingers, but eight notes in C to C. The solution: after finger 3 plays E, **tuck your thumb under** your hand to play F. Then fingers 2 3 4 5 continue.

Keep your wrist level and smooth. The thumb should start moving under while finger 3 is still playing, so there's no bump.

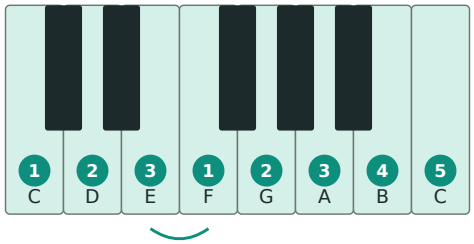
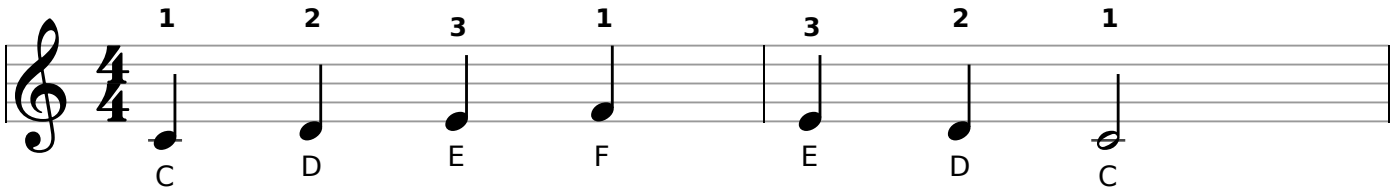


Figure 4.5 · Crossing the thumb

Practise · Thumb-under warm-up

Play C D E, then pass the thumb under to F. Back and forth.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Finger 3 over

Coming back down, it's the reverse: after the thumb plays F, finger **3 crosses over** the thumb to play E.

Practise · Crossing over

Play G F with 2 1, then cross 3 over to E. Then D C.

11. The C major scale

Eight notes, one octave, both hands.

What is a scale?

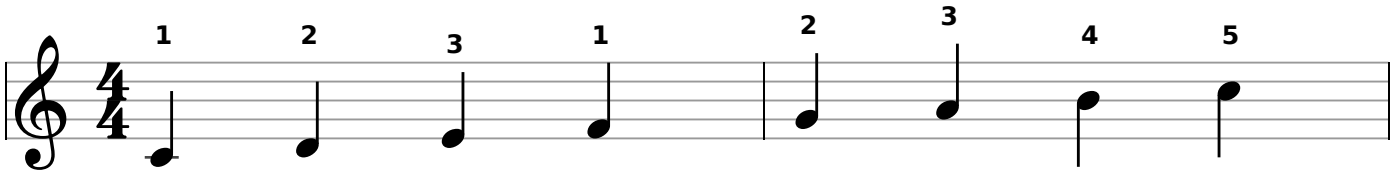
A **scale** is a ladder of notes, going up or down by step. The **C major scale** uses all the white keys from C to C: eight notes, called an **octave**.

Scales are the push-ups of piano playing. Pianists practice them every day to build even, smooth fingers.

Right hand fingering: **1 2 3, thumb under, 1 2 3 4 5**.

Practise · Right hand, up and down

Play the C major scale up and back down. Thumb under on the way up, 3 over on the way down.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

The left hand scale

The left hand goes **5 4 3 2 1**, then finger **3 crosses over** the thumb to A, then **2 1**.

Coming back down it's the mirror: **1 2 3** for C B A, then the **thumb tucks under** to G, and **2 3 4 5** finish the scale.

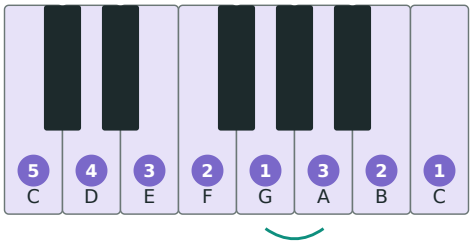


Figure 4.6 · The left hand scale

Practise · Left hand, up and down

Left hand: 5 4 3 2 1, cross 3 over, 2 1. Then back down.

Practise · Hands together (challenge)

Both hands, very slowly. The fingers cross at different moments, so think about each one.

12. G and F major scales

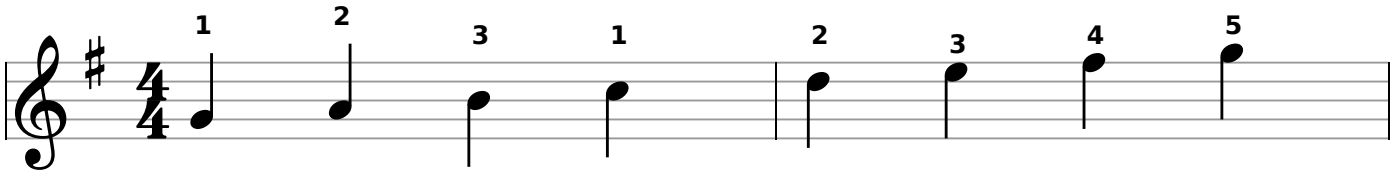
Scales with one sharp and one flat.

G major has F♯

The **G major scale** is G A B C D E **F♯** G. It uses the same fingering as C major: 1 2 3, thumb under, 1 2 3 4 5. Finger 4 lands on F♯.

Practise · G major, right hand

Thumb on G. Remember the F sharp near the top.



Opening example · 4/4 · G · finger 1 = thumb

F major has B♭

The **F major scale** is F G A **B♭** C D E F. Its right hand fingering is different, because a thumb on a black key is awkward: **1 2 3 4**, thumb under to C, then **1 2 3 4**.

Practise · F major, right hand

Fingers 1 2 3 4 for F G A B flat, thumb under to C, then 1 2 3 4.

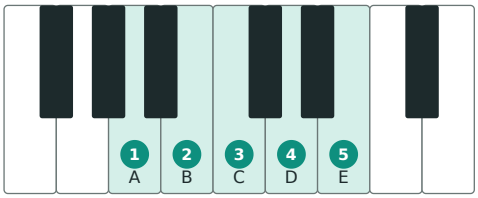
13. Major and minor

Happy and sad sounds, and A minor.

A minor position

Music in a **minor** key often sounds sad, mysterious or serious. Compare C D E (major) with A B C (minor). The middle note is closer to the bottom.

Put your right thumb on the A just below Middle C. Your fingers now cover **A B C D E**, all white keys.

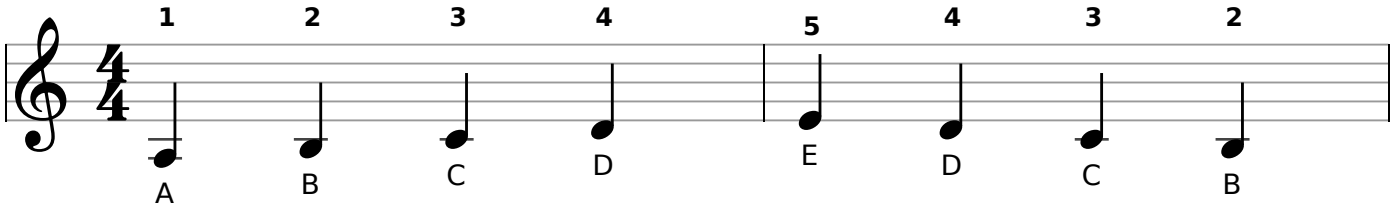


A minor position: thumb on A

Figure 4.7 · A minor position

Practise · A minor five-finger

Up and down in A minor. Listen to the darker colour.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

> **Review · ear training**
>
> Listen. Major or minor?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** Major That was C major: bright and open.

> **Review · ear training**
>
> And this one?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** Minor That was A minor: a darker, more wistful colour.

Practise · A sad little song

A melody in A minor. Play it gently.

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14. Go Down, Moses

A spiritual in A minor.

A minor spiritual

Go Down, Moses is an African American spiritual about the escape from Egypt. It's in a **minor** key, which gives it its serious, longing sound. Here it's in A minor.

Listen for the **G♯** in "let my people go": it pulls up strongly to A.

Practise · Go Down, Moses

Start on E, then up to C. Give the long notes their full value.



Opening example · 4/4 · Am · finger 1 = thumb

15. Hark! The Herald Angels Sing

Mendelssohn's carol, in F major with B♭.

Hark! The Herald Angels Sing

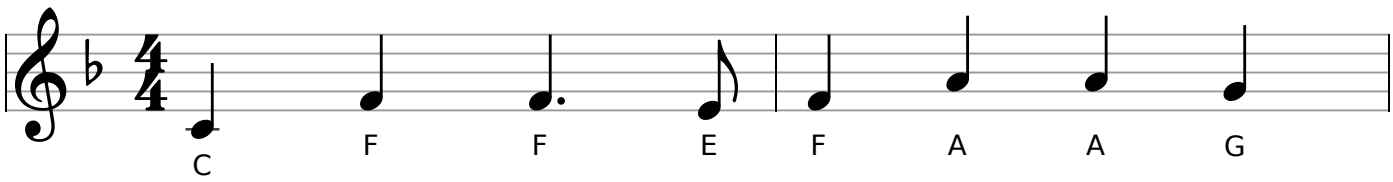
Charles Wesley wrote the words in 1739. The tune comes from a piece Felix **Mendelssohn** composed in 1840, and the two were joined in 1855.

We'll play it in **F major**, so every B is **B**♭. Most of it sits in F position (thumb on F), with a few reaches: down to the C below for the opening note, and up to C and D at the top.

Look for the **dotted rhythm** ("long-short") on "her-ald" and "glo-ry".

Practise · Lines 1 and 2

"Hark! the herald angels sing, Glory to the newborn King…" Then the second line ends low.



Opening example · 4/4 · F · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Line 3

"Joyful, all ye nations, rise…" Repeated high Cs, then a jump down to F.

Practise · Lines 4 and 5

"With angelic host proclaim…" and the famous ending, "Hark! the herald angels sing, Glory to the newborn King!"

Practise · Dress rehearsal

The whole carol, with hints.

Practise · Your recital

This is your performance: no keyboard hints this time. Take a breath, sit tall, and play it from start to finish. Tap "Show me" only if you get stuck.

16. Joy to the World

A carol that opens with a whole scale, walking down from high C.

Joy to the World

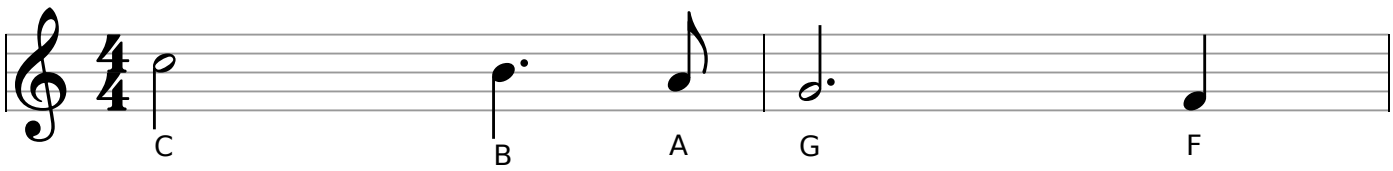
Isaac **Watts** wrote the words in 1719. The tune, called "Antioch", was arranged by Lowell **Mason** in 1839.

The first line is simply the **C major scale**, walking down from high C to Middle C. Use your scale fingering: start with finger 5 on high C, and cross finger 3 over your thumb after G.

Watch for the **dotted** notes: "long-short".

Practise · Line 1

"Joy to the world! The Lord is come." Walk all the way down the scale.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Lines 2 and 3

"Let earth receive her King…" Climb back up to high C, then two little falling phrases.

Practise · The ending

"And heaven and nature sing…" Repeated notes, then a leap to high C and home.

Practise · Dress rehearsal

The whole carol, with hints.

Practise · Your recital

This is your performance: no keyboard hints this time. Take a breath, sit tall, and play it from start to finish. Tap "Show me" only if you get stuck.

17. O Come, All Ye Faithful

A grand Christmas hymn in G major, with F sharp.

O Come, All Ye Faithful

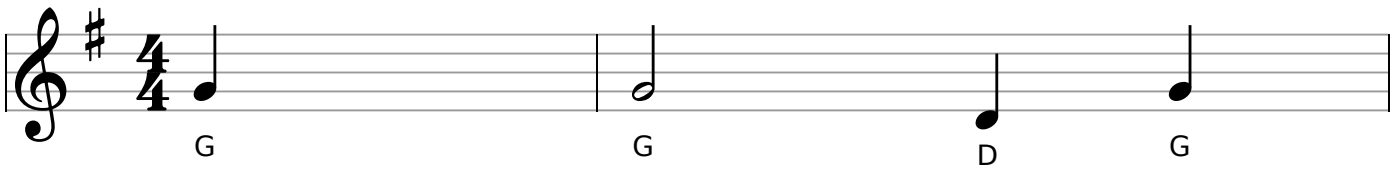
This hymn began in Latin as **"Adeste Fideles"**. The tune is usually credited to John Francis **Wade**, around 1745.

We'll play it in **G major**, so every F is **F♯**. It starts with a one-beat **pickup** on G.

It has three parts: the verse, a middle line that starts on high D ("Come and behold Him"), and the famous refrain, "O come, let us adore Him", which climbs a little higher each time.

Practise · The verse

"O come, all ye faithful, joyful and triumphant…" Remember F sharp.



Opening example · 4/4 · G · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · The middle line

"Come and behold Him, born the King of angels…" Start high on D.

Practise · The refrain

"O come, let us adore Him…" three times, each a step higher, then "Christ the Lord".

Practise · Dress rehearsal

The whole hymn, with hints.

Practise · Your recital

This is your performance: no keyboard hints this time. Take a breath, sit tall, and play it from start to finish. Tap "Show me" only if you get stuck.

Can I do this independently?

Try these at your piano with hints and note labels turned off. Tick a box when you can do it comfortably; return to the matching lesson when you need a reminder.

- ☐ Use landmark notes to move to a new position.
- ☐ Recognize sharps, flats, and the key signatures introduced here.
- ☐ Play the taught scales with their suggested fingering and relaxed thumb crossings.
- ☐ Hear and describe the difference between major and minor.

My next practice goal

What sounded better? What still needs work?
